countervailing coalitions, which any emerging and potentially threatening power would have to confront. China, too, has these nightmares. It cultivates an aura of overwhelming power and invincibility to prevent resistance and forestall coalitions. Despite this, coalitions are forming in the region, and the accretion of Chinese military power is sought to be countered by a significant uptrend in military expenditures and security capabilities in all the major Indo-Pacific countries.

Is a China-centric world order a possibility? The US as a hegemonic power has presided over a world order dominated by the West, which has evolved and taken shape at least since the fifteenth century. The Portuguese and Spanish imperia were inherited by the Dutch and then by the British. The transitions from one empire to another took place within the larger frame of European culture and institutions. The US is the latest representative of Western dominance, not its progenitor, though it did expand and extend that dominance. For any aspiring non-Western hegemon, there is no such legacy to build upon, though China may claim a history of pre-eminence in Asia, which is more imagined than real. Thus, China cannot just step into the space hitherto occupied by the US. It will take sustained pre-eminence over a considerable period of time to create an international order ‘with Chinese characteristics’. It is more likely that a cluster of major powers, China included, could together occupy that space, and, in the best-case scenario, impart a degree of stability and coherence to the evolving international situation.

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It should be apparent that the historical and cultural trajectories of India and China are different, and the particularities of our respective civilizations are only dimly understood by the people of the two countries, including by scholars.

The most difficult challenge for India is how to manage the expanding asymmetry of power with China, even while China is also simultaneously shrinking the gap it still suffers vis-à-vis the world’s pre-eminent power, the US.